

A NOTEBOOK: BON BY LAKE LEMAN

Red beeches, shining poplars
And steep spruce behind the October fog.
In the valley the lake smokes. Already snow
Lies on the hillsides of the other shore.
Of life, what remains? Only light,
So that the eyes blink in the sunny
Noon of such a season. You say: this is,
And no capacity, no artfulness
Can reach beyond what is.
And memory, useless, loses power.

Kegs smell of cider. The vicar with a spade
Mixes lime in front of the school.
My son runs there on a path. Boys carry
Sacks of chestnuts gathered on the slope.
If I forget thee, Jerusalem,
Says the prophet, let my right hand wither.
Underground tremors shake what is,
Mountains crack and forests break.
Touched by what was and what will be
All that is crumbles into dust.
And neither memory nor striving ceases.

Autumnal skies, the same in childhood,
In adulthood and in old age, I won't
Stare at you. And you, landscapes
Feeding our hearts with mild warmth,
What poison dwells in you, that seals our lips,
Makes us sit with folded arms, and the look
Of sleepy animals? Whoever finds order,
Peace, and an eternal moment in what is
Passes without trace. Do you agree then
To abolish what is, and take from movement
The eternal moment as a gleam
On the current of a black river? Yes.

Czeslaw Milosz, 1953

from: Aleksander Fiut. *The Eternal Moment: The Poetry of Czeslaw Milosz*. Trad. Theodosia S. Robertson. Berkeley, Los Angeles: The University of California Press, 1990, p. VII.

